The Meerut pillar in Uttar Pradesh and the Topra pillar from Haryana were brought to Delhi in the fourteenth century CE by the medieval sultan Firuz Shah Tughlaq and set up on the Delhi Ridge and at Firoz Shah Kotla, respectively.[5] The places where they stood in Meerut and Topra have not been satisfactorily identified, leaving us in the dark about the reasons for those locations. Unlike the fourteenth-century sultan, whose chroniclers clearly described how these pillars were shifted to Delhi, Ashoka neither mentioned the places where he placed his edicts nor why he chose to position them there. Segments of Ashokan pillars were integrated into Sultanate architecture in the Lat ki Masjid at Hissar and in the Firuz Shah column of the Purana Qila at Fatehabad as well.[6] It has been suggested that the two segments were part of the same ancient column. While large parts of the original polish were removed for the Persian inscriptions, palimpsest traces of earlier writing can still be seen, though not, unfortunately, any Ashokan message, stray characters apart.

Some of these monoliths appear to have been placed close to pre-existing religious structures. Lauriya-Nandangarh, the only Ashokan column bearing these edicts which has survived in its entirety and still stands,[7] is located in the Gandak valley, not far from Bettiah in the Champaran area of Bihar. Here a series of mounds, mostly round at the base and conical on top, are also in evidence, some being pre-Ashokan burial grounds. In two of them (mounds M and N), human bones and a standing female figure imprinted on a small gold leaf were found, while at the bottom of one of them (mound N) was found the end of a fairly intact wooden post.[8] This female figure was given the appellation ‘Prithvi’ or earth goddess by the archaeologist Theodor Bloch, who excavated the mounds in the early years of the twentieth century. Bloch believed that that goddess was, in a hymn in the *Rig Veda*, entrusted with the care of the dead. Incidentally, this figure was also found impressed on a gold leaf at Piprahwa in Uttar Pradesh, again in a funerary mound and close to a